

Change Management, Problem-Solving & Decision-Making

Reference Guide | AJFC Professional Development Training Series

WHY THESE SKILLS MATTER IN CAA WORK

Community Action Agencies operate in one of the highest-change environments in the nonprofit sector. Funding shifts, regulatory updates, leadership transitions, and program restructuring are not exceptions — they are the rhythm of the work. Staff who can navigate change, solve problems at the root cause, and make decisions with structure are the ones who keep clients served well when conditions are unstable.

ADKAR: A FRAMEWORK FOR LEADING CHANGE

Originally developed by Prosci, adapted here for the Community Action context.

A	Awareness	Staff understand WHY the change is needed. Communicate the reason clearly and repeatedly.
D	Desire	Staff are motivated to support it. They see what is in it for clients and for the agency.
K	Knowledge	Staff know HOW to make the change. Training, process documentation, and clear instructions are in place.
A	Ability	Staff can actually do it. Skills are practiced and performance support is available during the transition.
R	Reinforcement	The change sticks. Accountability, recognition, and consistent follow-through prevent backsliding.

UNDERSTANDING RESISTANCE TO CHANGE

Resistance is not the enemy of change. It is information about where people are in the process.

Fear of the unknown	Staff do not know how the change will affect their role or workload. Communicate early and often.
Loss of control	Decisions made without staff input create distrust. Include voices before decisions are finalized.
Past failures	Prior change efforts that were not followed through undermine credibility. Acknowledge history.
Capacity concerns	Staff are already stretched. Build support, training, and transition time into every change plan.

IDEA: A PROBLEM-SOLVING FRAMEWORK

I	Identify	Define the problem clearly. Separate the symptom from the root cause. Ask: What is actually happening? Who is affected? What evidence do we have?
D	Diagnose	Explore causes using the 5 Whys or a fishbone approach. Ask: Is this a people issue, a process issue, or a resource issue?
E	Engage	Involve the right people. Frontline staff often hold the best solutions. Co-creating the solution increases buy-in and improves execution.
A	Act + Assess	Choose a solution, take action, and measure the result. In ROMA terms: What outcome are you targeting? How will you know it worked?

THE CAA DECISION FILTER

Before making a significant decision, run it through these four questions:

Mission	Does this option align with our purpose and values?
Client	How does this affect the people we serve?
Capacity	Do we have the resources to execute this well?
Compliance	Does this meet our regulatory and funder requirements?

APPLYING THESE SKILLS TOGETHER

- When a change is announced, locate it on the ADKAR model. Where are staff right now? That is where to focus.
- When a problem surfaces, resist the urge to jump to solutions. Use IDEA to diagnose before you act.
- When a decision needs to be made, pause and run it through the CAA Decision Filter before moving.
- Change, problems, and decisions do not arrive separately. Build the habit of applying all three frameworks together.

"Change is constant in CAA work. The organizations that thrive are those that build change competency into their culture, not just their policies." ~ Nicole L. Turner